

DIE WALKÜRE

Shown here is a scene in Act III from an 1899 production of Wagner's *Die Walküre* (The Valkyrie), the second opera in his Ring cycle, featuring eight female warriors, or Valkyries (from the old Norse, meaning "chooser of the slain").

Desperation and salvation

By the 1860s, Wagner's relationship with the Wesendoncks had broken up and the ban on his return to German territories had been lifted. After the staging of a revised version of *Tannhäuser* in Paris in 1861 proved a fiasco, his finances remained in a desperate state, his luxurious tastes far outreaching his income. Salvation arrived in 1864 in the person of Ludwig II, the 18-year-old ruler of Bavaria (see [box](#)). A star-struck admirer of the composer, Ludwig cleared Wagner's debts and gave him a lavish annual income. At the same time, the composer's more intimate needs were met by Cosima von Bülow, Liszt's daughter and the wife of Hans von Bülow, a conductor who premiered several Wagner operas. She became Wagner's mistress and had three children before she obtained a divorce and married him in 1870 (Wagner's first wife died in 1866). Wagner wrote his *Siegfried Idyll* for Cosima's first birthday as his spouse and after the birth of their son Siegfried.

Wagner rode the wave of assertive German nationalism that came with the creation of the German Empire, under Prussian rule, between 1866 and 1871. His comic opera *Die Meistersinger von Nürnberg* was a triumph from its first performance in 1868, hailed as representing the true spirit of the resurgent German